

Phase 2: Define



Class 9 · Monday, September 28, 2026

Tonight

- Phase 2 kickoff: what Define is and how it works
- System Definition: exactly what's due Oct 14
- Studio time: keep refining, start style-scapes

Phase 2: Define

The Four Phases

- Discover: Aug 24 to Sep 23
 - Research, sketching, high-contrast drawings, digitizing. Done.
- Define: Sep 28 to Oct 14
 - Build the system. You are here.
- Develop: Oct 19 to Nov 18
 - Apply the system: applications.
- Deliver: Nov 23 to Dec 9
 - Brand guide, process book, final presentation.

Why Define Comes First

- A logo isn't an identity. A system is.
- A system is a set of decisions: mark, color, type, imagery, voice
- Make the decisions now, then apply them in Develop
- Big picture first: does it feel like one brand?

Two Directions, All the Way Through

- Two businesses, one concept each
- Or two concepts from one business
- Both directions carry through all of Define
- System Definition covers both
- Mon Oct 19: narrow to one direction for the rest of the semester

Iterations



Digital Is Round One, Not the Finish

- Duplicate the artboard, change one thing, compare
- Iterate fast, and do a lot of it
- Black first, color later
- Shrink it, reverse it, put versions side by side
- Keep every round for your process book

What to Iterate

THE SYMBOL

- Line weight and contrast
- Angles, corners, curves
- Negative space
- Simplify: what can go?

THE TYPE

- Typeface and weight
- Case: upper, lower, mixed
- Tracking and kerning
- Custom letterform details

THE RELATIONSHIP

- Size of symbol vs. type
- Spacing between them
- Alignment and balance
- Horizontal vs. stacked

Get My Sign-Off First

No further system investigation until I've signed off on your logo, for each direction.

- Your logo should be as good as it can possibly be before you build on it
- Don't get it done just to be done
- Show me in class: I'll sign off, or tell you what to push
- Changes later are still possible, just a lot harder

How Sign-Off Works

- Each direction is signed off on its own
- Signed off on one? Move forward with that while you refine the other
- In class: show me during studio time or Wednesday's check-in
- Missed me? Email it to jkurtz@uakron.edu by Sun Oct 4
- Goal: everyone signed off by Mon Oct 5

Ready for Sign-Off?

Check your logo against this list before you show me.

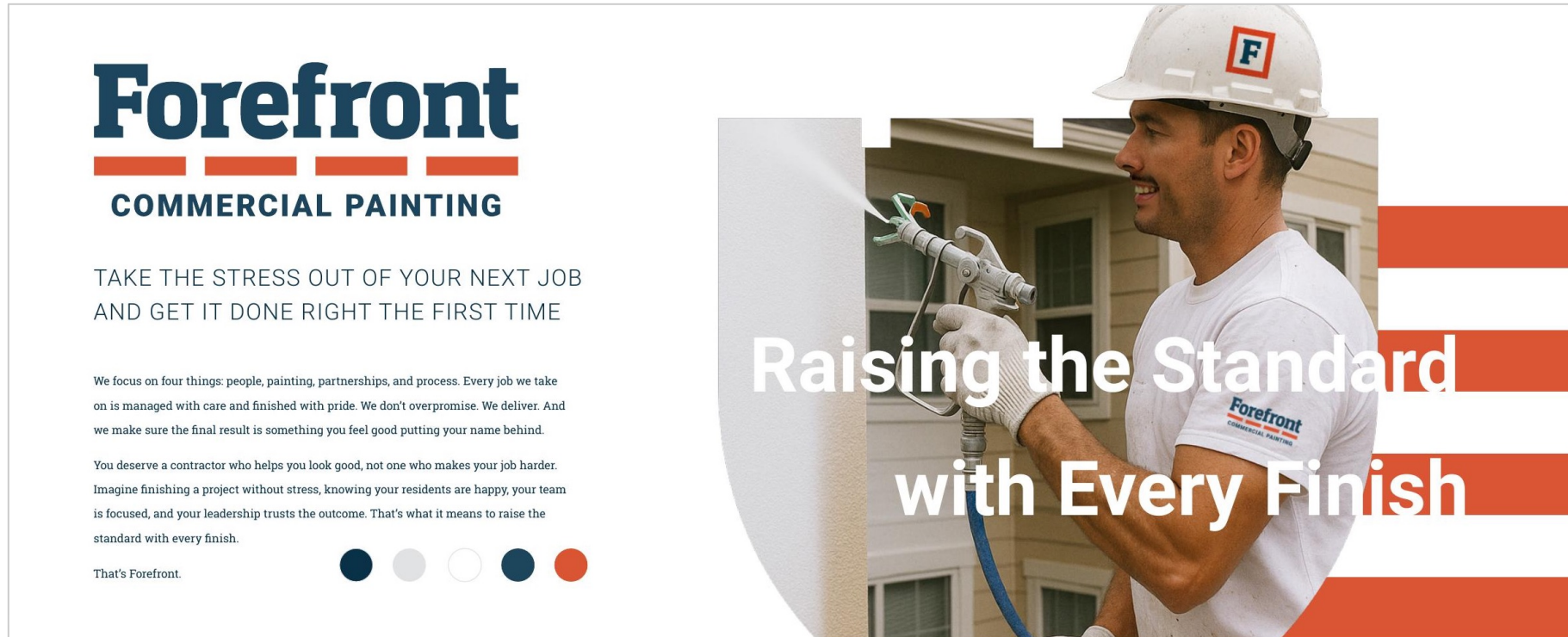
- Holds up at half an inch
- Works in black only, and reversed
- Clean construction: few anchor points, no Image Trace
- Type kerned by eye, not left at the default
- Compared against your sketch: it kept what made the sketch good
- Pushed through several rounds, not your first digital version

Style-Scapes

What's a Style-Scape?

- One designed board that shows how the brand looks and feels
- Your mark in context, not floating alone
- Type, color, imagery, and voice working together
- Designed, not collected: it's not a moodboard

Forefront Commercial Painting

The advertisement layout is divided into two main sections. The left section is a white rectangular area containing the company logo, tagline, and descriptive text. The right section is a photograph of a painter in a white hard hat and t-shirt, using a spray gun on a wall. The painter's t-shirt has the Forefront logo on the sleeve. The background of the photograph features horizontal orange and white stripes. The headline 'Raising the Standard with Every Finish' is overlaid in white text on the right side of the image.

Forefront

COMMERCIAL PAINTING

TAKE THE STRESS OUT OF YOUR NEXT JOB
AND GET IT DONE RIGHT THE FIRST TIME

We focus on four things: people, painting, partnerships, and process. Every job we take on is managed with care and finished with pride. We don't overpromise. We deliver. And we make sure the final result is something you feel good putting your name behind.

You deserve a contractor who helps you look good, not one who makes your job harder. Imagine finishing a project without stress, knowing your residents are happy, your team is focused, and your leadership trusts the outcome. That's what it means to raise the standard with every finish.

That's Forefront.

**Raising the Standard
with Every Finish**

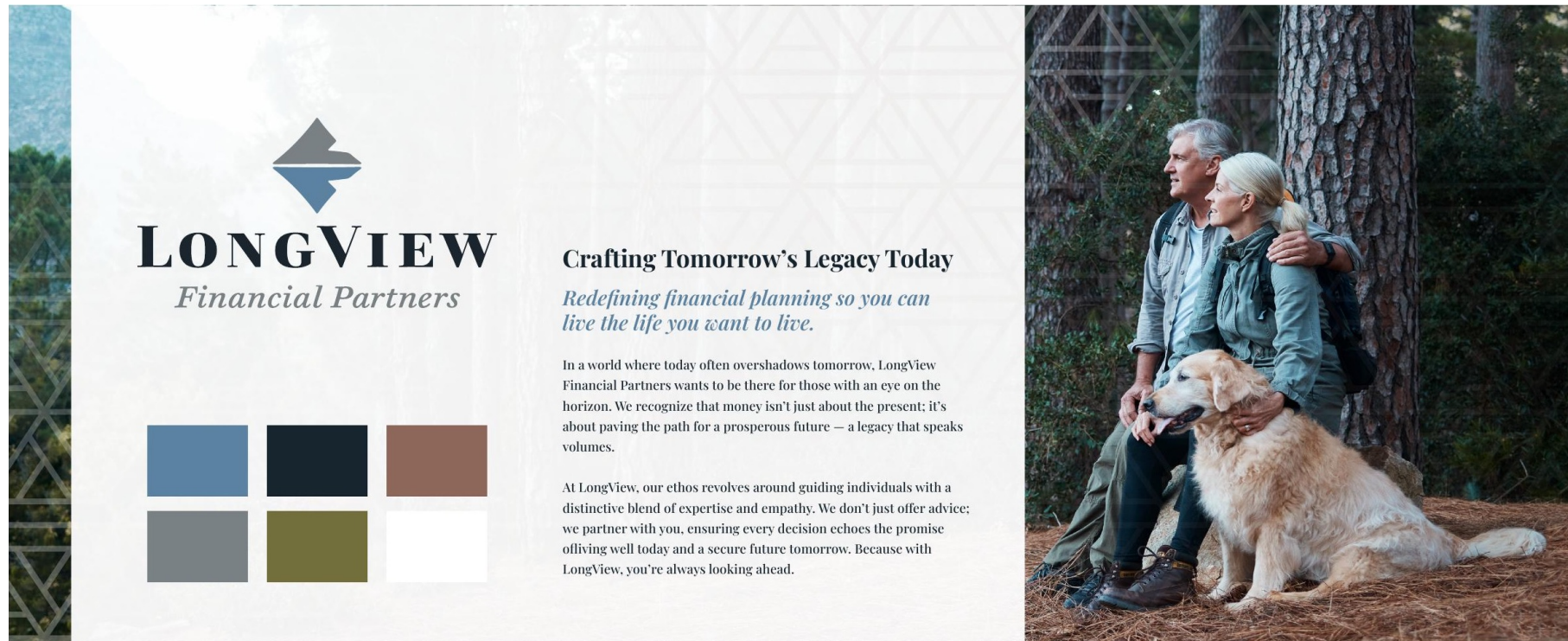
KURTZ client work. Logo, headline, voice, palette, photography, and a graphic device pulled from the mark.

Alliance Ghostwriting



KURTZ client work. Texture, brushwork, and highlighter marks carry the brand's rebellious voice.

LongView Financial Partners



KURTZ client work. A pattern built from the mark becomes a supporting element.

NEOLAX



**EMPOWERING THE NEXT GENERATION OF ATHLETES TO
LEAD WITH CHARACTER & COMPETE WITH HEART.**

At **NEOLAX**, we're more than just lacrosse. We build confident players and stronger teammates through our **G.R.I.T. mentality**: Gratitude, Relationships, Integrity, and Teamwork.

Whether it's your first time picking up a stick or your next step toward elite competition, our programs are designed to challenge, support, and elevate every athlete's journey.

STEP UP. STAND OUT. JOIN THE NEOLAX TEAM.



KURTZ client work. The mark on apparel shows the system working on a real touchpoint.

What Goes on a Style-Scape

- Logo
- A headline and tagline, set in your typefaces
- A short paragraph in the brand's voice (no lorem ipsum)
- Color palette
- Imagery: a photography or illustration direction
- Supporting graphic elements: patterns, shapes, textures

How to Start

- Go back to your research: personality, audience, competitors
- Fast and loose first: several quick directions per concept
- Pick the strongest, then refine it
- Placeholder photography is fine: you're showing a direction

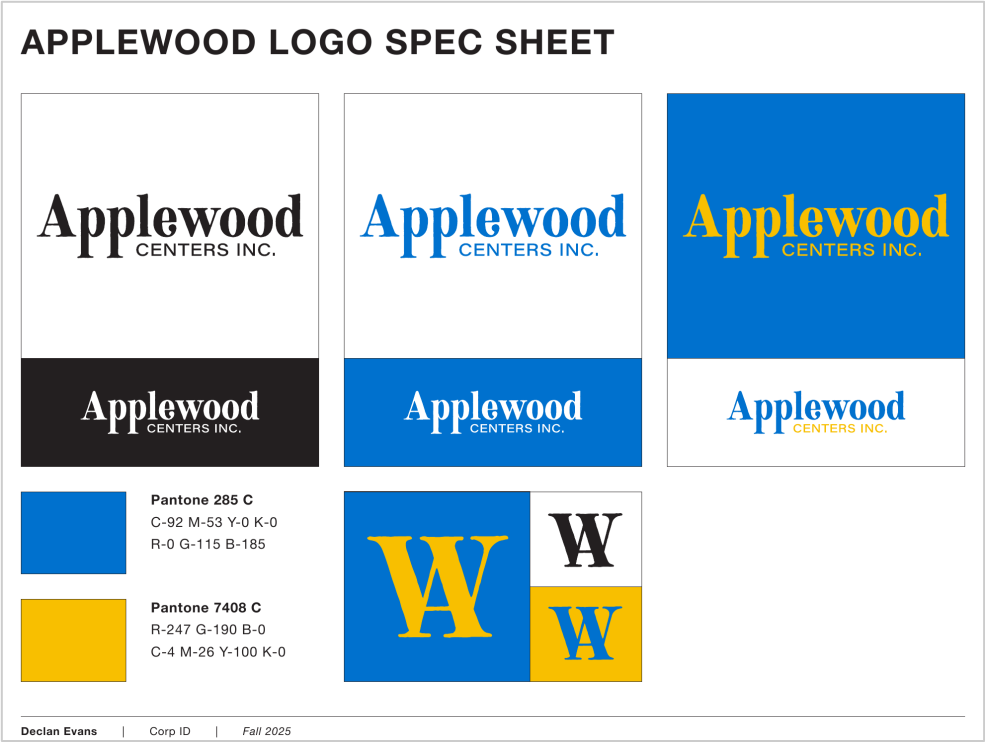
Lockups

Lockups

A lockup is a fixed arrangement of your symbol and type. You define them once, then never rearrange them.

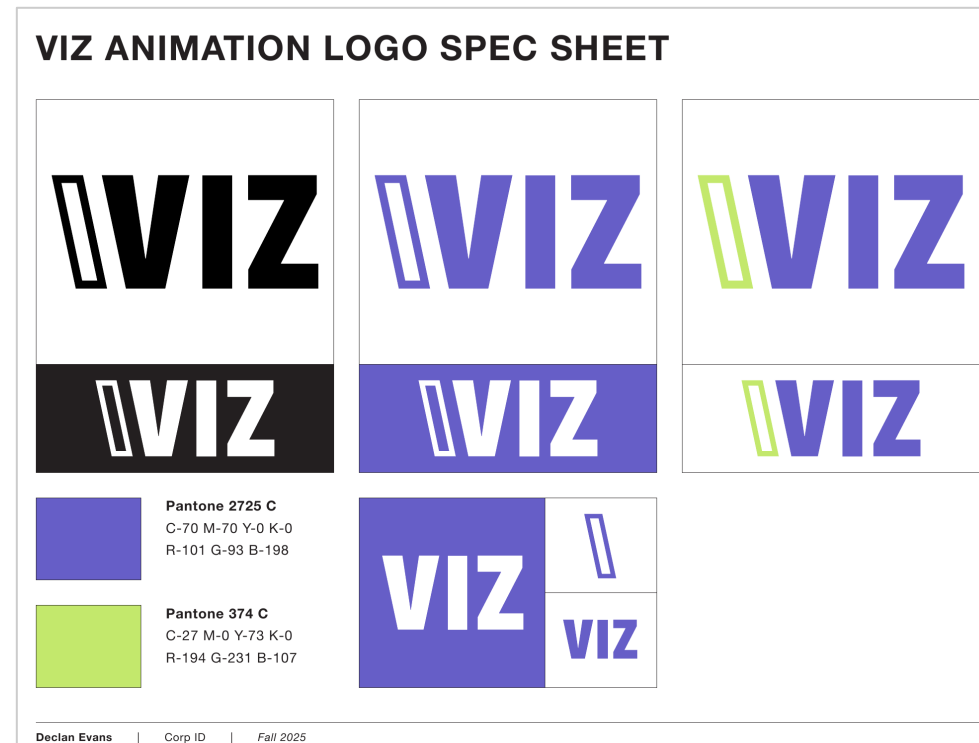
- Primary: the default, used most often
- Secondary: the alternate arrangement (horizontal or stacked)
- Icon only and wordmark only
- Every lockup also reversed, and in one color

Lockups in Practice



Past student example (Fall 2025): black, color, and reversed versions, plus the icon on its own.

Lockups in Practice



Same student, another brand: the full lockup, then the symbol and wordmark broken out separately.

Lockup Rules

- Clear space: measured from a unit of the mark itself
- Minimum size: the smallest it can go and still read
- No stretching, recoloring, or rearranging

Supporting Elements

Color Palette

- 3 to 6 colors, each with a job: primary, accent, neutrals
- Every color gets HEX, RGB, CMYK, and Pantone values
- Pick Pantone from a swatch book, not the screen
- Test it on white and on dark backgrounds

Typography

- One or two typefaces, a few weights
- Name the exact weight: “Roboto Bold,” not “bold”
- A headline style and a body style

And More

- Imagery: what the photography or illustration looks like
- Graphic devices: patterns, shapes, lines, textures
- Voice: how the brand sounds in a headline
- Pull these from your mark and your research

System Definition

The Format

- A Quick Reference Style Guide, one per direction
- Two pages per direction
- Page 1: logos, typography, color
- Page 2: style-scape

One Direction, Two Pages

PAGE 1: LOGOS, TYPE, COLOR

LOGOS



TYPOGRAPHY

Outfit SemiBold

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz 1234567890

Outfit Regular

ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ
abcdefghijklmnopqrstuvwxyz 1234567890

COLOR

				
HEX#: 127C11 RGB: 18, 124, 17 CMYK: 98, 22, 100, 13 PMS: 2258 C	HEX#: 2D332E RGB: 45, 51, 46 CMYK: 75, 59, 67, 61 PMS: 447 C	HEX#: FFFFFFFF RGB: 255, 255, 255 CMYK: 0, 0, 0, 0 PMS: WHITE	HEX#: 979495 RGB: 145, 148, 149 CMYK: 46, 36, 36, 2 PMS: Cool Gray 7 C	HEX#: 74B85C RGB: 116, 184, 92 CMYK: 68, 0, 95, 0 PMS: 360 C

Quick Reference Style Guide

EASEHOUSE, KURTZ client work

PAGE 2: STYLE-SCAPE

STYLE SCAPE



Get The Most Out Of Your Home

Your home is more than a project. It's where life happens, where value is built, and where the right improvements can make a real difference. That is why we focus on helping homeowners make smart, informed construction decisions.

We take the time to understand your goals, explain what areas of your home are worth updating, and guide you toward improvements that deliver real value, whether that means preparing to sell or simply making your home work

EASEHOUSE
PREP · REPAIR · RENOVATE

Quick Reference Style Guide

Same system, in context

Page I Checklist

- Logos
 - Primary and secondary lockups, icon only, reversed versions
- Typography
 - Each typeface and weight named, with an A to Z specimen
- Color
 - Each swatch with HEX, RGB, CMYK, and Pantone

What to Turn In

- Two Quick Reference Style Guides, one per direction
- A written rationale for each direction, tied to your research
- One PDF, submitted in Brightspace
- Due Wednesday, October 14, before class · 10%

How It's Graded

Both guides are graded together.

PROCESS	10	STYLE-SCAPE	10
Explored several style-scape directions first	5	Reads as one brand, true to your research	5
Kept refining the mark after digitizing	5	Built from your system: logo, type, color	5
LOGOS & LOCKUPS	12	RATIONALE & PROFESSIONALISM	6
Primary lockup refined, production-ready	4	Rationale explains why, tied to research	3
Secondary lockups: alternate, icon only	4	On time, clean files, proper naming	3
Works reversed and in one color	4		
COLOR & TYPE	12		
3 to 6 colors, each with a clear role	4		
Complete values: HEX, RGB, CMYK, Pantone	4		
Exact weights named, clear hierarchy	4		
		TOTAL: 50 POINTS	

What's Next?

- Mon Sep 28 and Wed Sep 30: refine marks, get my sign-off
- Sun Oct 4: last day to email me for sign-off
- Mon Oct 5 and Wed Oct 7: style-scapes, lockups, color and type
- Mon Oct 12: critique the whole system, draft your rationale
- Wed Oct 14: System Definition due
- Mon Oct 19: narrow to one direction, Phase 3: Develop begins

Studio Time

Tonight: Studio Time

- Keep refining your digital marks, both directions
- Think you're ready for sign-off? Wave me over
- Signed off? Start style-scapes

Wednesday

- Small group check-in on your digitizing, plus sign-offs
- Then open studio: refine marks, or style-scapes once signed off
- Bring your research, you'll need it

Questions?

Then let's get to work.